

What Gets Cropped Out: The Sublime, the Everyday, and Epistemic Justice

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Introduction

In the classic film Jurassic Park, John Hammond does not fail because he lacks intelligence or resources. He fails because he cannot hear the people who are right. His mathematician, Ian Malcolm, warns him repeatedly that the system is unstable and the consequences will be catastrophic. Hammond does not argue back, but simply dismisses these warnings because they do not fit the picture he has in his mind.

This paper argues that what happened between Hammond and Malcolm is not just a story about arrogance, rather a story about aesthetics, specifically about how the way we are trained to see beauty determines whose knowledge we are capable of taking seriously. I argue that the Kantian Sublime, the overwhelming aesthetic experience that ultimately glorifies human reason, functions as a moral filter that produces epistemic injustice by training the perceiver to dismiss any knowledge that does not match their grand vision. The corrective I propose is Yuriko Saito's everyday aesthetics, which asks us to expand our attention to include the unglamorous, the cautionary, and the ordinary. This expansion is not just a philosophical nicety, but a moral obligation, because justice requires us to first learn how to see what we have been conditioned to ignore.

The paper proceeds in four steps. First, I establish what the Kantian Sublime is and why it is structurally self-congratulatory. Second, I show how this produces testimonial injustice, the dismissal of knowers whose testimony threatens the perceiver's vision. Third, using Saito's critique of scenic aesthetics, I show how this deepens into hermeneutical injustice, where the

very tools needed to understand cautionary knowledge are made unavailable. Finally, I argue that Saito's everyday aesthetics is the corrective, and that cultivating it is a requirement of justice.

A few key terms need defining upfront. The sublime, as Kant uses it, is the experience of encountering something so vast or powerful that our senses are overwhelmed, but our reason steps in and recognizes its own ability to comprehend it. Scenic aesthetics, Saito's term, is the cultural habit of valuing only the dramatic and spectacular, the postcard view of the world. Everyday aesthetics refers to the aesthetic experience of ordinary life, including the mundane, the unpleasant, and the functional. Epistemic injustice, developed by Miranda Fricker, is injustice done to someone as a knower, taking two forms here: testimonial injustice, where someone's testimony is dismissed not because it is wrong but because the listener finds the speaker unworthy; and hermeneutical injustice, where the conceptual tools to understand an important truth simply do not exist within a given world (Fricker, Ch. 1). Finally, the aesthetic filter is the unconscious perceptual screen through which we decide, before any rational evaluation, what is worth seeing and worth hearing.

Part One: The Sublime and the Self

Kant distinguishes the sublime from the beautiful in a straightforward way. Beauty is about form and boundaries, where we find something beautiful when its shape fits our perception cleanly. The sublime is different. It arises from the formless and the overwhelming. As Kant writes, "the beautiful in nature is a question of the form of the object, and this consists in limitation, whereas the sublime is to be found in an object even devoid of form, so far as it immediately involves, or else by its presence provokes, a representation of limitlessness" (Kant, p. 90). A hurricane, a galaxy, an open ocean at night, none of these have clean edges, but all of

them can trigger the sublime. This is the *first premise*: the sublime is triggered by what exceeds our senses, not by what fits within them.

What makes Kant's account philosophically interesting is what he says happens next. The experience of the sublime does not end in defeat. When something overwhelms our senses, our reason steps in and recognizes that even if we cannot contain the storm with our eyes, we can think about it, name it, and place it within a larger framework. This produces something closer to pride than mere pleasure. As Kant puts it, "...but for the sublime one merely in ourselves and the attitude of mind that introduces sublimity into the representation of nature" (Kant, p. 93). The storm is not sublime. Your mind's ability to comprehend the storm is, and that turns the awe inward. This is the *second premise*: the sublime is not humility before the world. It is the mind celebrating its own rational superiority over the physical world.

From these two premises, an important conclusion follows. If the sublime is the mind triumphing over what overwhelms the senses, and if this triumph makes the perceiver feel like the highest measure of value, then anything confirming their vision feels profound and anything contradicting it feels aesthetically wrong. The sublime produces a kind of perceptual self-centeredness, where the perceiver unconsciously becomes the judge of what is real and worth attending to. This is the *first argument*: the sublime trains the perceiver to devalue anything that does not affirm their grand vision, and this devaluation happens at the level of perception, before any rational judgment is made.

Hammond illustrates this well. Creating Jurassic Park, bringing extinct creatures back to life through genetic engineering, triggers what Kant calls the mathematical sublime, where the sheer scale of something produces mental agitation that resolves into a sense of human triumph. Kant writes, "Its view, and it feels itself elevated in its own estimate of itself on finding all the

might of imagination still unequal to its ideas" (Kant, p. 105). Hammond's awe at the park was, at its core, awe at himself. So when Malcolm arrived with warnings grounded in probability theory and chaos, they were not just unwelcome. They were aesthetically dissonant, interrupting the sublime experience Hammond was living inside, and feeling wrong not because he had evaluated them carefully but because they did not fit his picture.

This pattern appears beyond fiction too. Consider the recurring figure of the visionary founder so consumed by the beauty of their innovation that every internal warning becomes illegible to them. The warning is not refuted. It is simply felt to be out of place, which is not a failure of logic but a failure of perception, and as I will now argue, also a form of injustice.

Part Two: Everyday Aesthetics and Testimonial Injustice

Testimonial injustice occurs when a speaker's testimony is dismissed not because it is factually wrong, but because the listener unconsciously finds the speaker unworthy (Fricker, Ch. 1). What this paper adds is a claim about where this sense of unworthiness can come from, which is not always social prejudice around race or gender, but aesthetic experience itself.

When a perceiver is in the grip of the sublime, their aesthetic filter is already calibrated to find certain kinds of knowledge worth hearing and other kinds worth ignoring. This is the *third premise*: when testimony is perceived as aesthetically dissonant, it gets dismissed on perceptual grounds before it is ever rationally evaluated.

Malcolm's warnings were, in Kantian terms, the opposite of the sublime. Precise, probabilistic, and unglamorous, they pointed not to the grandeur of what Hammond had built but to its fragility. Within Hammond's aesthetic world, this kind of knowledge had no beauty and therefore no authority. As Saito notes, "even the seemingly simple reaction, such as our response to the unsightly stain or dirty spot on our shirt, upon closer examination, turns out to be

dependent upon further conceptual and contextual considerations, though rarely do we recognize, let alone articulate, such cognitive factors" (Saito, Ch. 1, p. 33). The "aesthetic radar" had been set by the sublime, and the sublime does not register caution as meaningful. The *second argument* follows: testimonial injustice here is produced aesthetically rather than socially. The knower is silenced not because of who they are, but because of how their knowledge sounds inside the perceiver's aesthetic world.

Part Three: Everyday Aesthetics and Hermeneutical Injustice

Hermeneutical injustice is more fundamental. It occurs when the conceptual tools needed to understand an important truth simply do not exist within a given world (Fricker, Ch. 7). This is where Saito becomes essential.

Saito argues that Western culture has trained us to find value only in the spectacular and dramatic, what she calls scenic aesthetics. As she writes, our aesthetic preferences "often affect and sometimes determine our worldview, actions, the character of a society, the physical environment, and quite literally the course of history" (Saito, Ch. 1, p. 4). When entire categories of reality become scenically invisible, the conceptual frameworks needed to understand them disappear too. This is the *fourth premise*: scenic aesthetics creates gaps not just in perception, but in shared understanding.

She illustrates this by noting that "we tend to admire those landscapes which can be made into a nice picture, but remain indifferent to other parts of nature which do not lend themselves to a nice pictorial composition" (Saito, Ch. 2, p. 6). So we do not just fail to appreciate unglamorous landscapes, but also fail to protect them because we have no aesthetic framework within which their value registers as real.

The broken fences, the statistical warnings, the lysine contingency. These were the wetlands of Jurassic Park, ecologically critical but scenically invisible. Hammond's scenic aesthetics did not just make him unwilling to hear Malcolm. It made him unable to understand him, because the conceptual tools Malcolm's warnings depended on had no place in the world Hammond's aesthetic training had built. The *third argument*: scenic aesthetics produces hermeneutical injustice. The knower is not just dismissed. The language they speak has been made socially unavailable.

Part Four: Everyday Aesthetics as the Corrective

If the problem is aesthetic, the solution must be too. Saito's everyday aesthetics provides exactly this.

She argues that our aesthetic life is much wider than the art world suggests, including the mundane, the functional, the transient, and the unpleasant.

Saito writes:

my notion of the aesthetic is decidedly not honorific, in contrast to its common usage as well as what many attempts to define the aesthetic imply. As some recent writers point out, our aesthetic life includes not only pleasant, but also unpleasant experiences characterized as depressing, disgusting, or dreary. In my view, the aesthetic further includes reactions toward qualities such as dingy, nondescript, or plain-looking, which may or may not be accompanied by emotionally tinged quality like disgust. (Saito, Ch. 1, p. 2)

Crucially, everyday aesthetic experience is action-oriented. It does not make us passive admirers but participants who notice, repair, clean, and respond. This is the *fifth premise*:

everyday aesthetics trains attention toward what the sublime and scenic aesthetics crop out, and treats these not as distractions from beauty but as its proper subject.

The implications for justice are direct. A perceiver trained in everyday aesthetics does not look at a broken fence and see a minor interruption. They see an eyesore that signals something is wrong. They do not hear Malcolm's warnings as ugly noise. They hear the complexity of a living system and find it worth understanding. Everyday aesthetics recalibrates the aesthetic filter so that cautionary knowledge becomes perceptually available rather than invisible.

As Saito argues, "such seemingly trivial, innocuous, ordinary, mundane, or even frivolous aspects of our aesthetic life do have surprisingly serious, pragmatic consequences: environmental, moral, social, political, and existential" (Saito, Ch. 1, p. 4), extending in Chapter 2 to show how neglect of workaday environments in favor of dramatic scenic ones carries real consequences for how societies protect landscapes and whose warnings they take seriously. Because our aesthetic preferences shape what we protect and whose voices we hear, we are morally accountable for what our aesthetic training has made invisible. The *final argument*: if everyday aesthetics restores perceptual access to what has been cropped out, and if we are morally obligated to cultivate the perception that justice requires, then everyday aesthetics is a requirement of justice, and the aesthetic ought becomes a moral demand.

Objection and Response

One might object that the cases described here are simply instances of arrogance or poor judgment, ethical failures rather than aesthetic ones. Aesthetics is about taste, and justice is about reason, so conflating the two seems like a category error.

This is a fair concern, but it rests on an assumption that Saito questions directly. She argues that aesthetic preferences are never politically innocent, that they "often affect and

sometimes determine our worldview, actions, the character of a society, the physical environment, and quite literally the course of history" (Saito, Ch. 1, p. 4). Aesthetics and justice are not as separate as the objection assumes. Kant's own account of the sublime supports this further, describing not a rational judgment but an aesthetic one that shapes what reason then works with. By the time Hammond consciously evaluates Malcolm's warnings, he has already registered them as dissonant at the level of perception. Arrogance may be the visible symptom, but the aesthetic filter is what produces it. And since hermeneutical injustice cannot be corrected simply by reasoning more carefully, the correction has to begin at the level of perception, not argument.

Conclusion

What got cropped out of Jurassic Park was not just Ian Malcolm's warnings, but an entire way of seeing, one that finds complexity worth attending to, hears caution as meaningful, and treats a broken fence as seriously as a Brachiosaurus. Hammond's aesthetic training had built a world where only the grand and overwhelming felt real, and everything else barely existed at all.

This paper has argued that such cropping is not accidental. It follows from the Kantian Sublime, which places the perceiver's reason at the center of all value, and from the scenic aesthetics Saito critiques, which renders entire categories of reality invisible. Together they produce epistemic injustice in two forms: testimonial injustice, where knowers are dismissed because their testimony feels aesthetically wrong, and hermeneutical injustice, where the conceptual tools to understand cautionary knowledge do not exist within the perceiver's world at all.

Saito's everyday aesthetics offers the corrective, and as this paper has argued, it is not optional. The "aesthetic ought" implied tells us we are morally accountable for what our

aesthetic training has made us unable to see. Justice does not begin with better arguments. It begins with better seeing, and better seeing requires attending to what has been cropped out. We do not need to stop finding the Sublime extraordinary. We just need to stop letting it be the only thing that counts.

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